

DSC 482 — Debate Session

Table of Contents

- [1. Debate Topic](#)
- [2. Phase 1 — Preparation \(5 minutes\)](#)
- [3. Phase 2 — Opening Statements \(15 minutes\)](#)
- [4. Phase 3 — Assumption Attack \(10 minutes\)](#)
- [5. Phase 4 - Evaluation \(10 minutes\)](#)
- [6. Phase 4 — Evidence vs Projection \(10 minutes\)](#)
- [7. Final Synthesis \(10 minutes\)](#)
- [8. Ground Rules](#)

1. Debate Topic

Is large-scale AI job disruption within 1–5 years plausible?

Based on: Matt Shumer, “Something Big Is Happening” (2026)

You will debate the **structure** of the argument — not whether AI is “good” or “bad.”

- Team A (3 students): DEFEND the article.
- Team B (3 students): CHALLENGE the article.
- A-Observers (2 students) - SCORE and ANALYSE the team.
- B-Observers (2 students) - SCORE and ANALYSE the team.

2. Phase 1 — Preparation (5 minutes)

In your assigned group:

1. Write the author’s central claim in ONE sentence.
2. Identify TWO strongest arguments or mechanisms from the article.
3. Identify ONE key assumption the argument depends on.

Keep this concise. Bullet points only.

3. Phase 2 — Opening Statements (15 minutes)

- 5 minutes: DEFEND the article
- 5 minutes: CHALLENGE the article

Requirements:

- Refer to specific mechanisms from the text.
- Be precise about timeline and scope.

Post-mortem:

- 5 minutes to analyse the arguments of the other team.
- Your analysis should focus on the assumption attack.

4. Phase 3 — Assumption Attack (10 minutes)

5 minutes per team.

Each side must:

1. Identify one key assumption.
2. Argue why that assumption is fragile, unrealistic, or incomplete.
3. Finish with a short, summarizing closing statement.

Possible categories of assumptions:

- Technical (capability scaling)
- Economic (labor market absorption)
- Institutional (regulation, adoption speed)
- Behavioral (organizational change)
- Societal (politics/religion/culture)

5. Phase 4 - Evaluation (10 minutes)

5 minutes for observers to privately assign scores:

Criteria (0-2 points each):

1. Clarity of thesis
2. Use of mechanisms from the text
3. Identification of assumptions
4. Distinction between evidence and projection
5. Responsiveness under pressure

Total possible: 10 per team.

5 minutes to share (1 observer for each team only):

- Score
- One strong move from the debate
- One weak point for improvement exposed

6. Phase 4 — Evidence vs Projection (10 minutes)

Whole class discussion:

- Where does the article rely on measurement?
- Where does it rely on extrapolation?
- At what point does evidence become narrative?

7. Final Synthesis (10 minutes)

Answer together:

1. What must be true next year for this article to be clearly correct?
2. What observation would strongly falsify it?

Be specific and measurable.

8. Ground Rules

- Use the text.
- Distinguish:
 - Data
 - Authority
 - Extrapolation
- Avoid vague summaries.
- Focus on argument structure.

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